really steaming, shouting that if things were as bad as I made out, then it was my fault for never asking for help.

You never came to us! You never came to me!

Since boyhood that had been Willy's position on everything. I must come to him. Pointedly, directly, formally—bend the knee. Otherwise, no aid from the Heir. I wondered why I should have to ask my brother to help when my wife and I were in peril.

If we were being mauled by a bear, and he saw, would he wait for us to ask for help?

I mentioned the Sandringham Agreement. I'd asked for his help about that, when the agreement was violated, shredded, when we were stripped of everything, and he hadn't lifted a finger.

That was Granny! Take it up with Granny!

I waved a hand, disgusted, but he lunged, grabbed my shirt. *Listen to me, Harold.*

I pulled away, refused to meet his gaze. He forced me to look into his eyes.

Listen to me, Harold, listen! I love you, Harold! I want you to be happy.

The words flew out of my mouth: *I love you too…but your stubbornness…is extraordinary!*

And yours isn't?

I pulled away again.

He grabbed me again, twisting me to maintain eye contact.

Harold, you must listen to me! I just want you to be happy, Harold. I swear….I swear on Mummy's life.

He stopped. I stopped. Pa stopped.

He'd gone there.

He'd used the secret code, the universal password. Ever since we were boys those three words were to be used only in times of extreme crisis. *On Mummy's life.* For nearly twenty-five years we'd reserved that soul-crushing vow for times when one of us needed to be heard, to be believed, quickly. For times when nothing else would do.

It stopped me cold, as it was meant to. Not because he'd used it, but because it didn't work. I simply didn't believe him, didn't fully trust him. And vice